

More BB10 buzz

Research In Motion announced that Blackberry 10 will feature edge-to-edge keys, predictive vocabulary and predictive spacing



BitTorrent going legal?

BitTorrent said to looking for ways to distribute content legally through BitTorrent in 2013

centre of the hacking area. The creators, who are friends from various fields of computing (and interestingly, none from a proper robotics background), told us that they'd actually built a very competent model for the previous two days, but the person tasked with keeping the model safe, decided to not show up at all. While the original project was not in attendance, the rest of the Computer Club of India's team – Vijay, Anil, Anant and Chintan, took it upon themselves to build a new one from scratch, and they indeed build one. Also of note was a very interesting piece of software by Mr. Srivats P – a networking professional by day, he decided to pursue his interest in software development, and happily embraced the open source community for that. The result is 'Ostinato', an application that lets you inject any kind of network packet, containing any data that you want, into any network of your choice, provided that you



The event saw some interesting panel discussions

have a stable connection in place. Because the internal are pretty complicated, we'd advise you to check out his manual for the software's use, www.ostinato.org.

We also got to know about a very interesting shift in terms of industry guidelines. We met Mr. Nirbheek Chauhan, who claims to be an open-source warrior, so much so that even the company that he works for, Collabora, only develops open-source material, exclusively. Well done, we say, well done.

All of that was a refreshing change from the technical aspect of the conference, but as the organizers had made a point of emphasizing, the event was about so much more than that. To drive home the point some genuine thought fodder was being doled out with some very interesting talks that were organized. One

such talk that really left an impression was concerned with the moral side of foss – on what open-source really means. Because believe it or not, the question is still in existence. To be specific here, let us ask you a question that will pull you into the loop as well – “Exactly how open-source is your code when the website you host it on, github, is a closed source presentation?”. That is something that we had honestly never thought about, and we're sure few of us have. But it truly goes on to show that the people who are really going all-out in the pursuit of open-source goodness, will not spare the slightest detail to make sure that the entire community is on the same page.

The Conclusive Take

It was painful to see that in India the idea of open source was temporarily put on the back burner, when the conference was put on hold in 2010. From an economy which piggybacks on its IT fame, we expected better. Which is why it was good to know that the organizers decided to go through with the 2012 iteration of FOSS.IN.

Mr. Chitnis resonated with the audience when he said that it is really not difficult to get hold of technological talks



Things kicked off with the welcome note

these days. Heck, even foss.in was available as a live stream over its course. But people get together to be in the presence of other similar souls; to keep our faith that in any and every endeavour that we embark upon, we cannot be alone. To realize first-hand that we really can be more than the sum of our parts, and that as a focussed group, we are capable of bringing about the paradigm shift in software sourcing that the industry so desperately needs, but refuses to accept.

HIGHLIGHTS OF THE EVENT

- 'Big Data', 'Node.js', 'Cloud Computing' et al were common buzzwords, and the coverage was deep and entertaining. Just goes on to show how fast the industry is evolving, and it is good to see the event is keeping pace.
- The showcased hardware and software were the latest cutting-edge offerings/in-the-works from its creators. KDE showed off their 'MER' operating system for tablets, with a 'Plasma Active' core. They forked the dead 'MeeGo' code from the Nokia-Intel base, and recreated the OS in their own vision. Although the presented version is still a little rough around the edges, we could see good potential in this new OS.
- Wikipedia is thinking about changing its entire structure of operation. 'Wikidata' is a new concept where the actual, minimalist data will be pulled out of the current Wikipedia entries, and stored centrally. This would help with better implementation of Wikis in other languages, of which there are currently few. This would also open up a world of possibilities with Machine Learning, as the extracted data would actually be more comprehensible for machine input than the current 'essay' form of writing that Wikipedia employs.
- A KDE mini-conference was also organised, which showcased the latest in KDE software development, and showed the path for contributing to the KDE community.

Just when all of this was going through our mind, something happened that really was the perfect representation of the actual state of affairs in the India, concerning this field. One of the attendees decides to question the panel at an open-source conference whether open-source makes any sense at all, because apparently the Joker said that “if you're good at something, never do it for free” – that's when you sympathise with the disappointment that the organizers sometimes refer to. This is not to put down Batman, Joker or anybody else related to the immortally awesome legend that is 'The Dark Knight', but really the laughable context in which it was brought up (we had to confirm for ourselves if that person was serious – he was). That, ladies and gentlemen, is why aliens don't talk to us.